Learn the Signs. Act Early.

Milestones by 3 Years

TABLE OF CONTENTS | PAGE 10 OF 13 | ALL PAGES ↓

For Everyone

MAY 15, 2026 • ESPAÑOL

WHAT TO KNOW

- Learn about the developmental milestones that most children do by 3 years of age.
- See important information to share with your doctor.
- Find tips and activities you can do for your 3-year-old.



Ways to monitor milestones

How your child plays, learns, speaks, acts, and moves offers important clues about your child's development. Developmental miles things most children (75% or more) can do by a certain age.

Milestone checklists

Check the milestones your child has reached by 3 years by completing a checklist, available below and in three additional formats:

- CDC's free *Milestone Tracker* mobile app, for iOS and Android devices
- Web-based Digital Online Checklist
- Printable checklist PDF

Keep in mind

Learn the Signs. Act Early. materials are not a substitute for standardized, validated developmental screening tools.

What most children do by 3 years

Click the links below to view a photo or video of each milestone.

Social/Emotional Milestones

- Calms down within 10 minutes after you leave her, like at a childcare drop off
- Notices other children and joins them to play

Language/Communication Milestones

- Talks with you in conversation using at least two back-and-forth exchanges
- Asks “who,” “what,” “where,” or “why” questions, like “Where is mommy/daddy?”
- Says what action is happening in a picture or book when asked, like “running,” “eating,” or “playing”
- Says first name, when asked
- Talks well enough for others to understand, most of the time

Cognitive Milestones (learning, thinking, problem-solving)

- Draws a circle, when you show him how
- Avoids touching hot objects, like a stove, when you warn her

Movement/Physical Development Milestones

- Strings items together, like large beads or macaroni
- Puts on some clothes by himself, like loose pants or a jacket
- Uses a fork

SEE ALSO
More about physical development

Share with your child’s doctor

Things to share and consider

- What are some things you and your child do together?
- What are some things your child likes to do?
- Is there anything your child does or does not do that concerns you?
- Has your child lost any skills he/she once had?
- Does your child have any special healthcare needs or was he/she born prematurely?

You know your child best. Don't wait. If your child is not meeting one or more milestones, has lost skills he or she once had, or you concerns, act early. Talk with your child's doctor, share your concerns, and ask about developmental screening.

If you or the doctor are still concerned

- Ask for a referral to a specialist who can evaluate your child more; and
- Call your state or territory's early intervention program to find out if your child can get services to help. Learn more and find t at cdc.gov/FindEI.

KEEP READING

Concerned About Your Child's Development?

Tips and activities

What You Can Do for Your 3-year-old



As your child's first teacher, you can help his or her development.

As your child's first teacher, you can help his or her learning and brain development. Try these simple tips and activities in a safe w your child's doctor and teachers if you have questions or for more ideas on how to help your child's development.

- Encourage your child to solve her own problems with your support. Ask questions to help her understand the problem. Help her solutions, try one out, and try more if needed.
- Talk about your child's emotions and give him words to help him explain how he's feeling. Help your child manage stressful feel teaching him to take deep breaths, hug a favorite toy, or go to a quiet, safe place when he is upset.
- Set a few simple and clear rules that your child can follow, such as use gentle hands when playing. If he breaks a rule, show him instead. Later, if your child follows the rule, recognize and congratulate him.

More Parenting Tips and Activities

- Read with your child. Ask questions, such as "What is happening in the picture?" and/or "What do you think will happen nex she gives you an answer, ask for more details.
- Play counting games. Count body parts, stairs, and other things you use or see every day. Children this age are starting to le numbers and counting.
- Help your child develop his language skills by speaking to him in longer sentences than his, using real words. Repeat what h example, "need nana," and then show how to use more "grown-up" words by saying, "I want a banana."
- Let your child help with making meals. Give him simple tasks, such as washing fruits and vegetables or stirring.
- Give your child instructions with 2 or 3 steps. For example, "Go to your room and get your shoes and coat."
- Limit screen time (TV, tablets, phones, etc.) to no more than 1 hour per day of a children's program with an adult present. Do screens in your child's bedroom. Children learn by talking, playing, and interacting with others.
- Teach your child simple songs and rhymes, such as "Itsy Bitsy Spider" or "Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star."
- Give your child an "activity box" with paper, crayons, and coloring books. Color and draw lines and shapes with your child.
- Encourage your child to play with other children. This helps him learn the value of friendship and how to get along with othe
- Let your child play with playdough by squishing it, pressing it, pinching it, and making balls in different colors. This builds he finger muscles for writing, buttoning, and cutting.
- Give your child simple, healthy food choices. For example, at snack time ask, "Do you want carrots or an apple?"
- Play games to teach opposites. Get down low and say, "I am small." Then stand up and say, "I am big." Do the same thing fo quiet/loud.
- Play matching games. Ask your child to find objects in books or around the house that are the same.
- Play outside with your child. Go to the park or a walking trail. Allow your child plenty of time to choose what and how she w play. Join her and follow her lead.
- Help your child be ready for new places and meeting new people. For example, you can read stories or role play (pretend pla new places or things to help him feel more comfortable.
- Encourage your child to tell you her name and age.

TABLE OF CONTENTS | TABLE OF CONTENTS

- Milestones by 2 Months
- Milestones by 4 Months
- Milestones by 6 Months

SHOW MORE

SOURCES AND PAGE INFO

CONTENT SOURCE

National Center on Birth Defects and Developmental Disabilities (NCBDDD)

ABOUT THIS PAGE

Published: September 4, 2025

Updated: May 16, 2026

This page was last updated on this date. Updates may include minor edits, image changes, or other modifications to page content.

Reviewed: May 16, 2026

The information on this page was last reviewed by subject matter experts to ensure accuracy.

SOURCES

- *Special acknowledgments to the subject matter experts and others who contributed to the review of data and selection of deve milestones, especially Paul H. Lipkin, MD, Michelle M. Macias, MD, Julie F. Pajek, PhD, Judith S. Shaw, EdD, MPH, RN, Karnesha MPH, Jane K. Squires, PhD, Toni M. Whitaker, MD, Lisa D. Wiggins, PhD, and Jennifer M. Zubler, MD.*
- *Sincere gratitude to Natalia Benza, MD and José O. Rodríguez, MD, MBA for their thoughtful review of the Spanish-language tr these milestones.*